powerful Baloch party, the Anjuman-e-Watan, rejected the idea and sought a separate state.[29] This was similar to the NWFP, where the Khidmatgars demanded a separate Pashtunistan. Both these issues continued to simmer making them appealing 'pressure points' against Pakistan, and the 1965 war gave India a reason to exploit them. Senior Congress leaders began asking the government to move beyond moral and diplomatic sectors to provide 'concrete' support to the Pashtuns. Though it is unclear what exactly 'concrete' meant, there is little room for disambiguation about what India and Pakistan's leadership would have imagined it to be, which was armed and financial support. A serving member of parliament, Retired Colonel Bashir Hussain Zaidi, was dispatched to Afghanistan to meet Ghaffar Khan in late-September and explore the possibility of reigniting the Pashtunistan issue. The 85-year-old leader was 'full of vigour and enthusiastic about waging his struggle for emancipation from Pakistan's rule'.[30] Within India, the Pakhtoon Jirga-e-Hind, an outfit advocating for independent Pashtunistan, also pressured the government to move beyond the war of words. In November 1965, addressing a fully packed Lok Sabha, EAM Swaran Singh invited Ghaffar Khan to resume his struggle for Pashtun independence from Indian soil and promised all support that he would require in that pursuit.[31] Soon the All India Radio (AIR) broadcasted that Pashtun nationalists were setting up administrative centres in Pakistan's tribal areas and NWFP, to advance the Pashtunistan campaign.[32] Such proactive advocacy on the Baloch and Pashtun issues had an impact on how India came to be viewed in Kabul.

Afghanistan's reaction to the war, from an Indian perspective, was muted and ambiguous. Though it supported the UN's ceasefire initiatives throughout the war, Kabul did not criticise Pakistan's aggression. Instead, when the fighting was at its peak and Indian planes were bombing Pakistani cities, Kabul officially protested India's targeting of Peshawar and Kohat. Considering them part of Pashtunistan and not Pakistan, Kabul asked keep them out of an India-Pakistan war.[33] As ironic, logical and shrewd as it was, Kabul's complaint seemed equally bizarre to India. Afghanistan was undermining Indian military counteractions without being wanting to be seen as doing it at Pakistan's behest. Adding fuel to fire, Bhutto mentioned in his UN speech that Afghan King Zahir Shah had assured Pakistan's president Ayub Khan that: 'I as a king give you assurance, I as a